

making a few mistakes, and then heading right back to the books to learn some more. It will take some trial and error to get there.

The other problem that you might face while working with Regex is that each of the characters are simple when they are alone, but put them all together and they can wreak havoc for someone who does not know what to do with them. The more you work with the characters, the easier things will get. Practice until you have become a pro!

To understand Regex, you need to understand the characters. Here is a quick look at all of them -

Backslash \

It usually helps to start with the backslash because it is significantly different from all the other Regex characters, as you will come to see. The backslash provides a bridge between Regular Expressions and plain text. The backslash possesses the quality of being able to ‘escape’ a character. Escape in this sense means that it can turn the Regex character into plain text.

For example, Your goal page is

- `/folder?pid=123`

The primary problem here is that the question mark has its own meaning and value in the world of Regex. So we need it to be read as plain text (just an ordinary question mark). So what we will do with Regex is this -

- `/folder\?pid=123`

Now that there is a backslash in front of the question mark, GA will read it only as a question mark and not attribute any extra value to it, which is exactly what you set out to do.

Pipe |

The pipe is one of the most simple of all of the Regular Expressions. It is, therefore, one of the first ones that regular GA users like you and us should be aware of. The pipe means ‘or’.

For instance, think about a blog that is based on packaged drinking water. They might use the terms ‘Bisleri’ and ‘Aquaflina’ more than once. So instead of setting filters for both separately, the bloggers can use Bisleri|Aquaflina with their GA keyword report. It will help them find all the examples of the searches that were made on their blog using either of the keywords.

Let’s look at one more example. Many website may have more than one ‘thank you’ page. While they are named differently, they may want to count the leads as being in the same category. So if the first page is called